

Africa Plus and the Ethiopian Crown

A record of our conversation, the full detail of the January expedition, and where we would like to build together.

FROM	B. Amechi — Manager, 19Keys · Co-Founder, High Lvl Media · Africa Plus
FOR	Scheril Murray Powell, Esq. — Special Representative to the African Diaspora, the Crown Council of Ethiopia Deacon Solomon Kibriye — the Royal Ethiopian Trust Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie — the Crown Council of Ethiopia
SHARED WITH	19Keys · ChakaBars · Omega Axsal — hosts of the Ethiopia expedition
OUR CONVERSATION	Sunday, 6 September 2026
WHAT IS AHEAD	Meskel in New York — 26 and 27 September 2026 The Ethiopia New Year Expedition — 5 to 15 January 2027

THANK YOU

Ms. Murray Powell, thank you for convening this and for the year of consistency that led to it. Deacon Kibriye, Lij Nebyat — thank you for your time on a Sunday and for the history you gave us. This document is the summary promised on the call. It is written so that 19Keys, ChakaBars and our expedition lead have every detail, and so that you have everything about our work in one place.

01 Where We Stand

Two moments sit in front of us. A historic Meskel weekend in New York at the end of this month, and an eleven-day Ethiopian expedition in January that we have been building all year. Our conversation made clear that these are not two separate things. They are the same relationship at two different altitudes.

- We are honoured to be on the invited guest list for the service at Abyssinian Baptist Church on Sunday 27 September, and grateful for the formal letter of invitation.
- We intend to be present in New York for both days — the Demera in Newark on Saturday the 26th, and the service in Harlem on Sunday the 27th.
- Our January delegation is thirty travellers, eleven days, Addis Ababa to Lalibela, timed to Gena. The full package is in Section 4.
- We would like the Crown Council and the Royal Ethiopian Trust to be part of that January journey by name, not as a courtesy line, and we would like to discuss what a working partnership looks like for both of us.
- We work entirely independently. Section 6 is an honest conversation about where we could use support, and about what we bring in return.

02 What We Heard From You

Recorded here so that 19Keys, ChakaBars and our team carry your words accurately, and so that nothing said on Sunday gets lost between us.

The Royal Ethiopian Trust — Deacon Solomon Kibriye

- The Trust is the charitable arm of the Crown Council — a crown institution, directed toward charitable and cultural work, registered as a 501(c)(3).
- Its work so far: educational charities in Ethiopia and across the diaspora; disaster relief, including hurricane damage in Jamaica; and historic restitution of royal heritage held in Western hands since the late 1800s, including an emperor's shield and his wife's hairpin, achieved through the Trust's own efforts and covered in the press.
- The Trust has helped rebuild a school that His Imperial Majesty Emperor Haile Selassie I established near his birthplace in eastern Ethiopia. It is in finishing work.
- The Trust is roughly three years old and is building its grassroots base — and the African diaspora, in North America, the Caribbean and everywhere else, is central to that base.
- On Ethiopianism: it is unity, and it crosses religion. There are Ethiopian Christians, Ethiopian Muslims, Ethiopian Jews. Religious and ethnic identity are secondary to Ethiopianism, which unites all. In Deacon Kibriye's words, unity is power.

The long work — Lij Nebyat Aklilu Demessie

- The Selassie Stand Up movement: a seven-year grassroots campaign that resulted in a statue of Emperor Haile Selassie I on the grounds of the African Union, achieved in the face of a government openly hostile to the idea, and

after refusing an offer to relocate the effort away from its Pan-African framing.

- Accompanying His Imperial Highness as advisor on the state visit to Jamaica, where agreement on a statue of His Majesty in Kingston took twenty seconds — against seven years in Addis Ababa.
- Work on the renovation of Holy Trinity, and a journey to the ancestral homeland in northern Shoa, where King Sahle Selassie held his palace before the line became emperors. Thousands came out. The clergy brought out the tabots and would not take them back inside until the royal party arrived.
- The African Union statue spurred a local movement in northern Shoa, where residents petitioned to build a statue of Emperor Zera Yacob, the philosopher king — and the royal party ended up speaking beside it. What is started in one place becomes part of something larger.
- The historical thesis: the victory at Adwa in 1896 under Emperor Menelik II defeated the idea of white supremacy on the field, and Pan-Africanism was coined as a term in 1897. Ethiopianism is what made Pan-Africanism possible as a concept. By 1900 Ethiopia was represented at the global African conference through a Haitian proxy, and what Menelik began, Haile Selassie built upon.
- The suppressed history: Nelson Mandela trained in Ethiopia and travelled on an Ethiopian passport under another name to return and fight apartheid. Across Africa's conflicts the Emperor was at the forefront of efforts toward peace and unity, and that record was buried after 1974.
- The question that matters most: there is inherent value in the assets, artifacts, traditions and culture of our forefathers — and the real challenge is who is now trying to own and commodify that, and remove us from what is rightfully ours.

Meskel — why these dates matter

- Meskel celebrates the finding of the True Cross. Empress Helena, mother of St. Constantine, went to Jerusalem to find the holy places and built the Church of the Holy Sepulchre — of which the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church is one of five custodian churches. Unable to find the buried Cross, she built a bonfire and had incense thrown into it, and the smoke revealed where it lay.
- Each year the Church builds the Demera in commemoration. Until 1974, the principal bonfire in the capital was lit by the Emperor himself, mirroring Empress Helena in Jerusalem, with the Imperial Army parading and the churches in procession. After the revolution, that ended.
- New York City does not permit public bonfires. The only church in the metropolitan area that lights one is in Newark, New Jersey — and this year that church has asked **His Imperial Highness Prince Ermias Sahle-Selassie Haile-Selassie to light it**. It is the first time a member of the Imperial family has lit a Meskel bonfire since 1974.

Abyssinian Baptist Church — the line that already exists

- Ethiopian merchants and seamen came to a church in Manhattan in the early 1800s and were told to sit apart because of their colour. They left and founded their own congregation, naming it after Abyssinia.
- When fascist Italy invaded Ethiopia in 1936, the church was at the forefront of raising funds for the resistance, and African Americans gave heavily through the Ethiopian World Federation.
- In gratitude, on his 1954 state visit, Emperor Haile Selassie I came to Harlem and gave the church a large silver processional cross, which it still displays in its sanctuary as an emblem.

- **Deacon Kibriye's grandfather and great-uncle made that cross.** They were jewellers to the Emperor. On 27 September, that history will be standing in the same room as the people who carry it.

Why we are taking this seriously

Africa Plus exists because culture built by our people is exported everywhere and owned almost nowhere.

Deacon Kibriye put the same idea in one sentence when he said Ethiopia exports enormous quantities of leather and then we buy Italian belts and shoes. Lij Nebyat put it another way when he asked who is commodifying our forefathers' heritage and removing us from ownership of it. That is our thesis, said back to us in your words.

There is real alignment here, and it goes well beyond a trip.

03 Who We Are

Africa Plus is a 19Keys initiative. In plain terms, it is a trade agreement between the Black diaspora and Africa — doing business directly with each other through media, tourism and real products, and keeping ownership at origin. What follows is what we have actually done, not what we intend to do.

19Keys — founder, Africa Plus and Supermind; host, High Level Conversations

- Four countries, four delegations. Every one left a contract, a cheque or a school behind.
- Sat with H.E. President Yoweri Museveni of Uganda for a full recorded conversation, coordinated through the Office of the President.
- Signed a multi-year Ugandan coffee partnership with Inspire Africa and purchased two containers at the source, for Supermind.
- Keynoted Impact Day at the University of Lagos, mentored the student founders, and handed business grants to five winning teams on stage.
- Funded schools and orphanages in Uganda and Ghana — beds, classroom lighting, computers, electricity.
- Seventy-two episodes of High Level Conversations, and sold-out rooms from the Royal Albert Hall to Bermuda's first financial literacy conference.

ChakaBars — founder, I Heart Africa; producer, The Africa Tour

- Produced the IShowSpeed Africa tour — twenty countries in one month, in-country from start to finish.
- 120 million views in a month and over two billion impressions. The largest streaming tour for Africa on record, and a measurable factor in Africa's biggest tourism year to date.
- Built a village in the Congo, assembling Vic Mensa, Lenny Kravitz and others to fund and finish it.
- Fifteen years of schools, clinics and orphanages across Congo and Ghana. Recipient of the BET International Global Good Award.

Omega Axsal — expedition lead

Founder of TheSoulFam and the operator leading the January journey — routing, logistics, ground partners and the day-to-day running of the delegation.

B. Amechi — manager and strategy

Nigerian-American producer and strategist, manager to 19Keys, co-founder of High Lvl Media, and the person building the media, delegations and systems behind every Africa Plus trip. Your primary point of contact.

How we work, and why it matters here

Media is how our business runs. 19Keys is known first for the podcast, so the value of a delegation is never only the people in the room — it is the millions who see the content afterward. When IShowSpeed came to Africa it moved economies in several countries, and the person who took him there is leading this trip. That is the machine we are offering to point at Ethiopia.

04 The Ethiopia New Year Expedition

Eleven days on the ground with thirty hand-selected leaders, creators, investors and athletes. Everything below is confirmed and live.

ELEMENT	DETAIL
Dates	5 to 15 January 2027 — eleven days
Route	Addis Ababa · Bishoftu crater lakes · the Rift Valley lakes · Arba Minch · Nechisar National Park · the Dorze highlands · Lalibela
Anchor moment	Gena — Ethiopian Christmas — 7 January, in Lalibela
Delegation	Thirty seats. Intentionally small. Leaders, creators, investors and athletes, selected rather than sold to.
Hosts	19Keys — conversation and community · ChakaBars — wellness and movement · Omega Axsal — expedition lead
Seat	\$3,500 per traveller, against a standard rate of \$4,444. Private room upgrade \$400. Shared same-gender accommodation included.
Included	Accommodation for the full journey · domestic flights · ground transport · two to three meals daily · cultural access · wellness experiences · all three hosts throughout · flight-booking support · visa guidance · a private in-trip mastermind
Not included	International flights · travel insurance · visa fees · personal spending · drinks outside meals · tips · optional upgrades

What the delegation is there to do

- **Meet at a high level.** Every Africa Plus delegation is built around real conversations with the people who actually hold the history and the decisions. That is why this call mattered so much to us.
- **Document it properly.** The trip is filmed and distributed. Ethiopia's story told at full value, to an audience that has largely never seen it.
- **Do business.** Coffee, goods, tourism, media and culture — with value added at origin and ownership kept there.
- **Leave something behind.** Presence means participation. That is the rule on every trip we run.

Where we are asking for your guidance

Lij Nebyat offered on the call to review our deck, suggest additions, help itemise and organise the tour, and share contacts on the ground — including for northern Shoa. We are taking that offer seriously and would like to act on it in the coming days.

Specifically, we want the monarchy's story to be present in this journey rather than absent from it: the sites, the ancestral places, the descendants, the people who served, and the questions worth asking. We would rather be guided to the right sources than assemble it ourselves and get it wrong.

Everything about the trip, in three links

- **The Africa Plus mission** — who we are, the four delegations behind this one, and the thesis. [Click here to open](#)
- **The Ethiopia partner page** — built for governments, tourism bodies, hotels and venues, operators, creators, investors and sponsors. This is the page to forward to anyone in your network who should be involved. [Click here to open](#)
- **The expedition and booking page** — dates, inclusions and seat reservation, for anyone you would like to send. [Click here to open](#)

05 New York, 26 and 27 September

WHEN	WHAT	WHERE
Saturday 26 September, 2:00 PM	Meskel eve. The Demera programme begins.	The Ethiopian Orthodox cathedral in Newark, New Jersey
Saturday 26 September, 4:00 PM	His Imperial Highness lights the bonfire — the first time a member of the Imperial family has done so since 1974	Same
Sunday 27 September, 10:00 AM	Meskel Day service, with His Imperial Highness present, commemorating Emperor Haile Selassie I's 1954 visit to Harlem	Abyssinian Baptist Church, Harlem
Sunday 27 September, following	The private luncheon hosted by His Imperial Highness	To be confirmed

What we understand, and what we would be grateful to confirm

- **Attire.** All white is encouraged; most attendees will be in Ethiopian national dress; nothing is required. We will come in white.
- **The luncheon.** Deacon Kibriye kindly said he would raise the question and expects we would be welcome. Ms. Murray Powell has escalated a request for 19Keys to have direct dialogue with His Imperial Highness there. We would be honoured, and we understand entirely that the circle is small. A yes or a no is equally welcome — we only ask to know in time to plan properly.
- **The programme.** We understand speakers are still being confirmed, including the possibility of Adam Clayton Powell III. If there is any role you would like 19Keys to play — a word, a panel, a filmed conversation — please tell us, and we will prepare for it properly rather than arrive unready.
- **The letter of invitation.** Gratefully received in advance. It is genuinely useful to us on the travel and planning side.
- **Filming.** We understand the weekend is being documented. We would like to bring a small crew and would rather coordinate with your production than work around it. We are happy to share what we capture.

06 Building Something Real Together

This section is written plainly, because you were plain with us and it deserves the same in return.

First, the part that is not conditional on anything

We want to be in New York for Meskel. It is an honour to be invited, the moment is historic, and we would not want to miss it. We are working to make it happen regardless of whether any support exists, and we are not asking for anything as a condition of showing up.

Second, the honest context

We work one hundred percent independently. There is no institution, network or parent company behind 19Keys funding this work — every delegation, every trip and every piece of content has been paid for out of what we build ourselves. Moving even a small team to New York for a weekend — 19Keys, myself and one content person, covering flights, lodging, ground transport and production — runs in the range of **\$5,000 to \$7,500**. For January, the production and marketing costs are considerably larger.

We say that not as a complaint but as context, because the most useful thing we can do is be clear with each other about what we each have and what we each need. Anything at all would help, and if nothing is available on the funding side, that is completely understood — there are other forms of support that may be worth as much or more.

Where support would make the biggest difference

1. **September travel.** Any contribution toward getting our small team to New York for the 26th and 27th. If that is not possible from within the Crown institutions, an introduction to someone in your network who supports this kind of cultural work would be just as valuable.
2. **Is there an ask of 19Keys?** If there is a speaking role, a panel, a blessing or a filmed conversation you would like from him at either event, please say so. And if such a role exists, is there a speaking budget attached, or an organisation in your network that holds one? We will say yes to the role either way — we simply want to ask the question openly rather than leave it unspoken.
3. **Institutional cover for January.** Letters, permits, ministry and tourism introductions, filming clearances — the kind of authority that opens doors we cannot open from the outside.
4. **Media and documentary support.** We are documenting both September and January. A media budget, or an introduction to a partner who funds cultural documentary work, would raise the quality and reach of what gets made about Ethiopia considerably.
5. **Marketing inside Ethiopia.** This is a real gap for us. Seats are available to Ethiopians as well as to the diaspora, and we currently have no distribution inside the country. If your networks can help with posts, flyers, church and community channels or local press about the January journey, that would open the trip to the people it is most about.
6. **Sponsored seats.** Is there a route through the Royal Ethiopian Trust, or through aligned organisations in your network, to sponsor seats for people who could never otherwise make this journey? We operate a nonprofit vehicle on our side if a nonprofit-to-nonprofit structure is cleaner, and we would gladly build that programme with you.
7. **A reading and viewing list.** Before January, we would be grateful for books, films and primary sources you trust, so that the history reaches our audience from the right mouths. Ms. Murray Powell has already started us with

“Grandpa Was an Emperor” and the Crown Council letters, and we are grateful for both.

What we bring to the table

- **Reach into exactly the audience the Trust says it needs.** Young, diaspora, ownership-minded, and already listening. Deacon Kibriye named grassroots support in the African diaspora as the Trust's central need. That is the audience we have spent a decade building.
- **Documented global exposure.** Both events, professionally captured and distributed across a platform with reach in the hundreds of millions.
- **Co-branded content and full credit.** A named role for the Crown Council and the Royal Ethiopian Trust in the January programming, and in what comes out of it.
- **A delegation carrying real capital.** Investors, operators, creators and athletes — people who can act on what they see, not a camera crew.
- **A record of leaving something behind.** A presidential conversation that became a coffee contract. Grants handed to five student teams on stage. Schools and orphanages funded in Uganda and Ghana.
- **A commitment to return every year.** This is not a single visit. Ethiopia is the next chapter of a body of work, and we intend to keep coming back.

The specific thing we would like to explore with you

Deacon Kibriye extended the coffee argument to leather — that Ethiopia exports the raw material and the finished goods come back to us with someone else's name on them. That is the exact problem Africa Plus was built to work on, and coffee is where we already have a working model.

19Keys owns Supermind, a coffee business. Ethiopia is coffee's origin. A line built with Ethiopian growers, tied by name to the work the Royal Ethiopian Trust is already doing in education and entrepreneurship, would send value in both directions — commerce for the growers, sustained funding and visibility for the Trust, and a story about ownership at origin that we could tell for years. We would like to put that on the agenda for our next conversation.

07 Next Steps

What we will do

- ☐ Bring 19Keys, ChakaBars and Omega Axsal fully up to date on this conversation. Done with this document.
- ☐ Send the full January trip deck and agenda to all three of you for review.
- ☐ Confirm our September travel plans and the size of our team as soon as we are able.
- ☐ Come to the next call with a clear proposal for what a Crown Council and Royal Ethiopian Trust role in the January expedition looks like.

What we would ask of you

- ☐ A full call mid-week, with 19Keys, ChakaBars and Omega Axsal joining from our side — Wednesday 9 or Thursday 10 September if either works. 19Keys is looking forward to speaking with you directly.
- ☐ Lij Nebyat's review of the January deck, and any named introductions on the ground you feel are right.
- ☐ The Jamaica Memorandum of Understanding, which Lij Nebyat kindly offered as a template — we would value seeing how that agreement was structured.
- ☐ The Crown Council New Year letter, which Ms. Murray Powell offered to share.
- ☐ Confirmation, when you have it, on the luncheon and on any role for 19Keys on the 27th.
- ☐ The formal letter of invitation, with our guests named.

Dates to hold

DATE	WHAT
Wed 9 or Thu 10 September	Full call — both delegations, with 19Keys
Friday 11 September	Ethiopian New Year. We intend to open the January campaign publicly on this date, and would welcome your networks amplifying it.
Saturday 26 September	Meskel eve — the Demera, Newark
Sunday 27 September	Meskel Day — Abyssinian Baptist Church, Harlem
5 to 15 January 2027	The Ethiopia New Year Expedition

In closing

Unity was the word that came up most on Sunday, in several different ways. We agree with it. Everyone in this conversation has skill sets, and everyone has gaps — particularly when entering a country and a culture that is not your own, where working with the right people on the ground is everything.

We would like to build this properly, and for a long time. Thank you for opening the door.

08 Contact and Links

PURPOSE	CONTACT
Manager · primary contact	B. Amechi — 510-381-5523 (also WhatsApp)
Partnerships	CNFDNT.AI@GMAIL.COM
Press and general	19KEYS@19KEYS.COM

- The Africa Plus mission. [Click here to open](#)
- The Ethiopia partner page — for anyone in your network who should be involved. [Click here to open](#)
- The Ethiopia expedition page inside the Africa Plus site. [Click here to open](#)
- The expedition and booking page — dates, inclusions and seat reservation. [Click here to open](#)

Prepared by B. Amechi, 6 September 2026, from the recording of the call of the same date. Background on the Royal Ethiopian Trust, the Jamaica Memorandum of Understanding and the Magdala restitution drawn from the Crown Council of Ethiopia's published material at [ethiopiancrown.org](#) and from Capital Ethiopia's reporting of 14 October 2024.